

# Embers of the Forsaken Keep

A Novel





## CHAPTER 1

# The Weight of *Ash & Embers*



he wind came down from the Grey Mountains carrying the smell of burnt cedar and something older—something that had no name in the common tongue, but which every **T**soldier recognised in the hollow of their ribs. Aelindra tightened the strap of her vambrace and said nothing.

Below, the valley curved like a wound in the earth, its floor dark with the remnants of what had been three villages not a fortnight past. The smoke still rose in thin, patient threads, as though the ground itself had not yet decided whether to forgive.

*“We should not have come this way,”* said the boy behind her. She did not turn. The boy said many true things. That was what made him dangerous to keep near and impossible to send away.



She counted the fires. Seven. No—eight, if the far glow past the treeline was theirs and not some shepherd’s accident. Eight fires meant a column, not a raid. A column meant orders. Orders meant someone, somewhere, had decided this particular valley was worth the cost of making it into a memory.

Aelindra had spent seventeen years learning the difference between decisions made in rooms and decisions that lived in the soil afterward. She had yet to find a word for the distance between them.

## CHAPTER 2

# Echoes in Stone



he fortress rose before them like the ribcage of some ancient god, half-buried in evening shadow. Its towers had once been proud; now they leaned toward tomorrow with the patience of monuments that had already learned to wait forever.

“Do you feel it?” Dorian’s voice carried that peculiar tremor that meant he was about to say something either brilliant or catastrophically foolish. There was no in-between with him.

“Feel what?” Aelindra kept her eyes on the gatehouse. Stone by stone, it was studying them as carefully as they were studying it.

*“The weight,”* he said quietly. *“The weight of everything that died here.”*



She had learned long ago not to argue with what Dorian felt. Where others saw ruins, he sensed echoes. Where others heard silence, he listened to the long, slow song of the earth remembering its own sorrows.

It was, perhaps, the only thing that separated them from the ruin-readers and the grave-singers—the ones who had learned to read the world’s grief and call it prophecy.



## CHAPTER 3

### Seren's Vigil

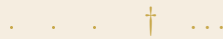


he night came early to the mountains, or perhaps it had never truly left. Seren watched from the watchtower, her fingers trailing along stone so old it had forgotten what colour **T** it had been in sunlight. The stars, when they came, arrived like promises nobody had believed in for centuries.

Below, the camp stirred with the small movements of soldiers settling in for the dark—the scrape of steel on whetstone, the murmur of prayers to gods with too many names. Somewhere, someone was singing. A soldier's song, which meant it was about loss, or wine, or both.

“You should rest,” came a voice from the tower stairs. Mael, his robes catching shadow like fabric was something he'd learned to wear instead of weave.

*“I will rest when the keep rests,”* Seren replied, not turning. *“And this keep has been awake for three hundred years.”*



Mael emerged onto the platform, the night wrapping around him like an old friend. He was older than stone, in his way—not in years, but in the way he carried the weight of knowing

too many endings before they happened.

“The stars say something different,” he offered.

“The stars always do. That’s what makes them stars instead of prophecies,” Seren replied, her gaze never leaving the horizon where the mountains met the dark.